

such as anthropomorphic paintings (see left) in which the landscape forms a human face, echoing both the Christian idea that people reflect God's creation, and the Hermetic idea of humans as a microcosm of the natural world around them.

Paracelsus's studies were rooted in observation, experimentation, and an interest in how different substances form associations with each other. His work can be viewed as an example of an early empirical approach to science, but he saw a special kind of magic in his methods.

The power of prophecy

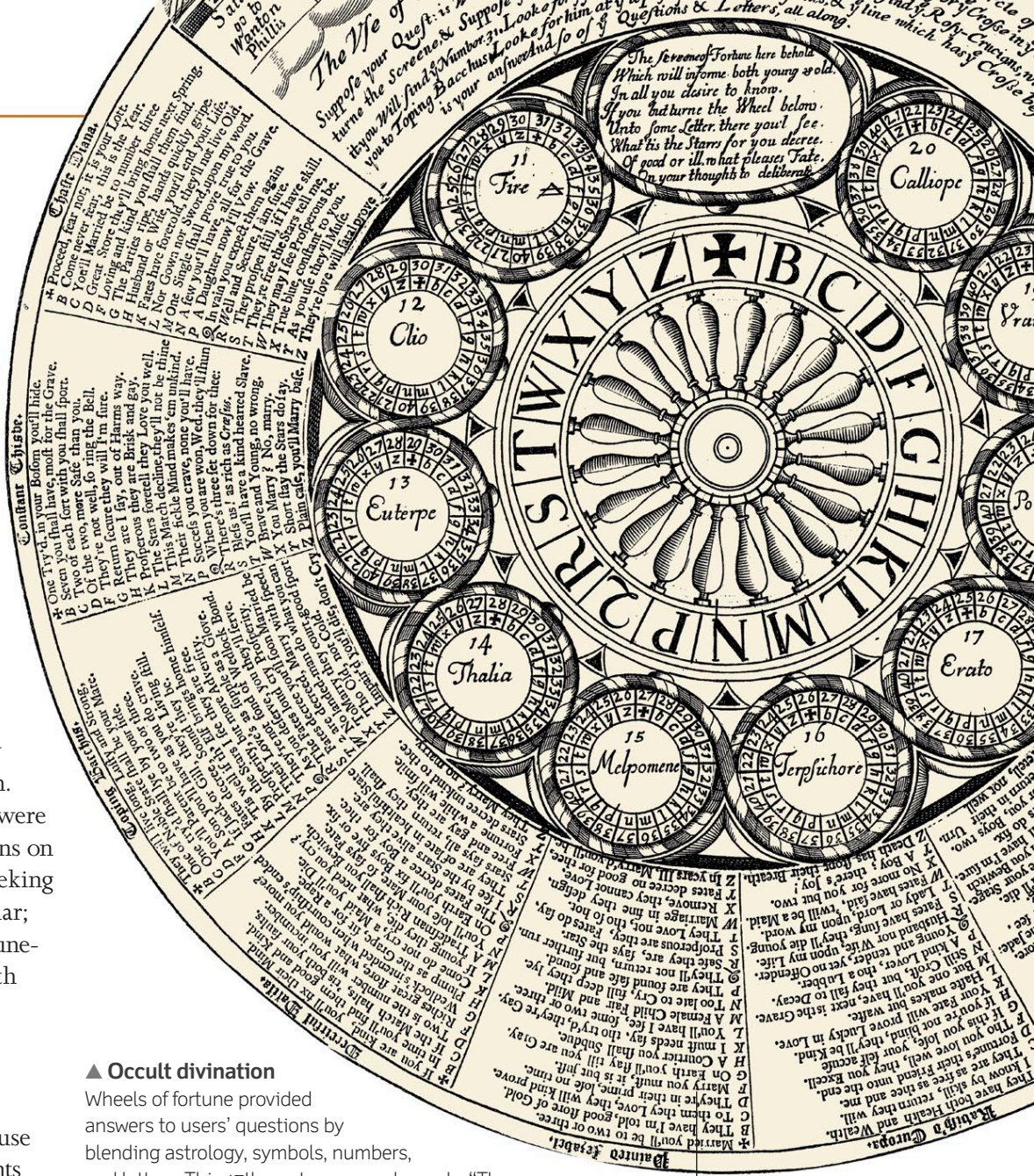
Renaissance philosophy contained a seemingly contradictory mix of prophecy and rationalism. At a time when the first scientific experiments were taking place, occult philosophers gave instructions on how to predict the future. Astral divination (seeking wisdom by reading celestial bodies) was popular; the wealthy collected astral talismans and fortune-telling games appeared. There were overlaps with natural philosophy, too: in *Coelestis physiognomonica* (1603), Italian scholar Giambattista della Porta presented astral divination in more naturalistic terms. His earlier treatise *Magia naturalis* (1558) had explored how natural philosophers could use philosophical thinking and practical experiments to probe the mysteries of a natural world that is underpinned by a rational unity rather than magic.



SIR ISAAC NEWTON (1642–1727)

Newton's nature

English physicist and mathematician Sir Isaac Newton is considered one of the greatest figures of the scientific revolution that began in the Renaissance and continued to flourish during the Enlightenment. Yet he probably saw himself principally as a natural philosopher. Newton was fascinated by how religion and practices such as alchemy contributed to an understanding of the natural world and its forces. Believing himself to be chosen by God to divine such truths, he undertook alchemical experiments. He also owned a large collection of alchemical texts, including one known as the *Musaeum hermeticum*, which refers to the Philosopher's Stone (see p.149), and another that says of alchemy, "... its occult may be made manifest only to men elected by God."



▲ Occult divination

Wheels of fortune provided answers to users' questions by blending astrology, symbols, numbers, and letters. This 17th-century example reads: "The Screene of Fortune here behold / Which will informe both young and old / In all you desire to know."

Turning the wheel selects one of a choice of outcomes listed around the edge